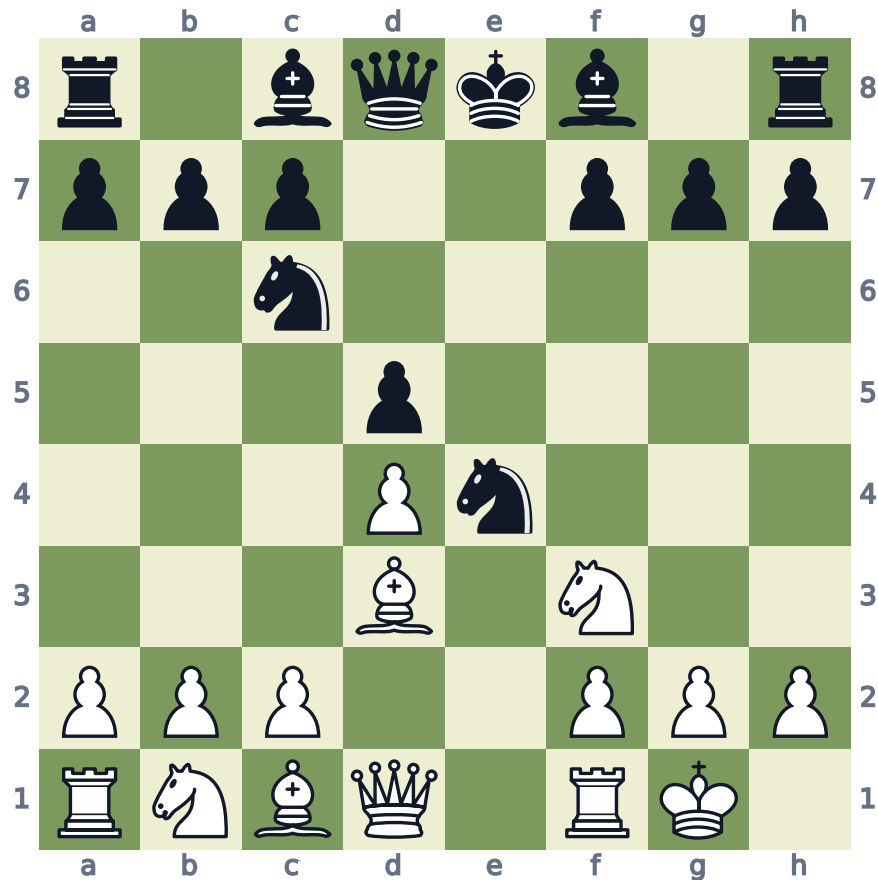


Petroff, Philidor, Scotch, and Other Open Games

Central exchanges, symmetrical positions, early gambits, and independent second moves



Meet Black's alternatives after 1.e4 e5 with active development and exact responses to their forcing ideas.

8 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Meet Black's alternatives after 1.e4 e5 with active development and exact responses to their forcing ideas.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The Petroff attacks e4 immediately and punishes careless symmetry.

PRINCIPLE 2

The Philidor is solid but restricts Black's dark bishop.

PRINCIPLE 3

Opening the center favors the better-developed side.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

A queen check is urgent even in a dubious gambit.

PRINCIPLE 5

Return a pawn when it ends the opponent's initiative.

PRINCIPLE 6

Symmetry still contains move-order and activity differences.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

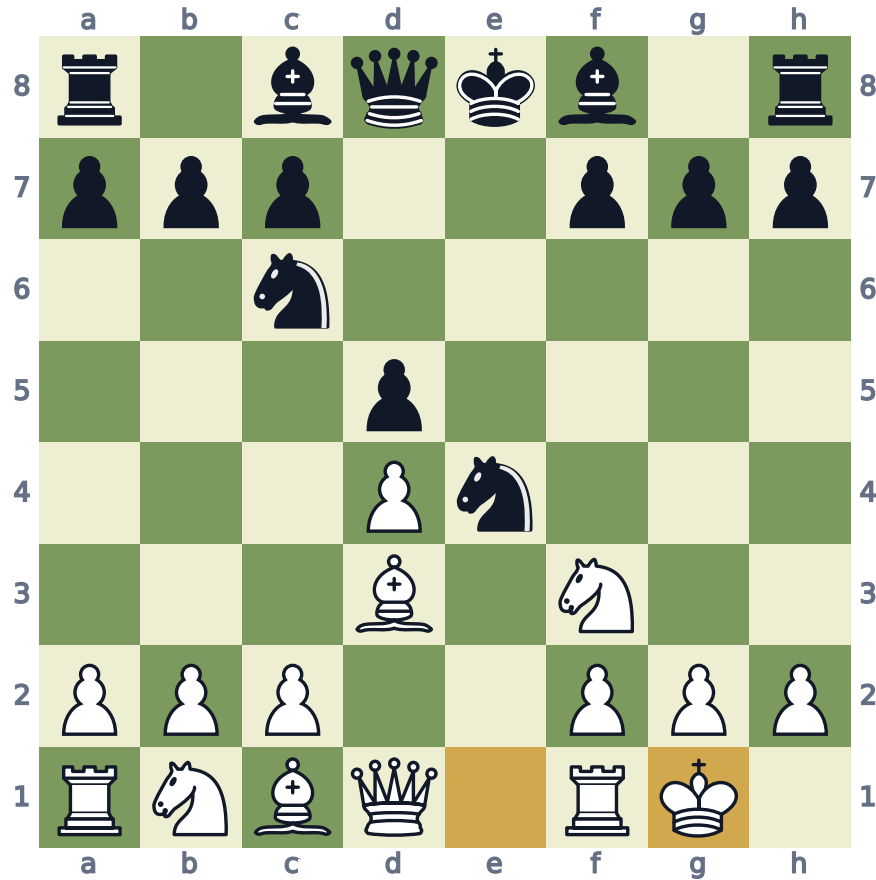
- | | | |
|-----------|--------------------------|--|
| 01 | Petroff main line | After the forced exchanges, d4 and Bd3 give White the easier development. |
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 | | |
| 02 | Petroff with 3.d4 | 3.d4 changes the question from pawn recovery to central activity. |
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 | | |
| 03 | Philidor exchange | Exchange on d4 when it opens lines against Black's cramped pieces. |
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 | | |
| 04 | Philidor ...Nf6 | The Hanham setup is solid; improve pieces before forcing matters. |
|
 | | |
| 05 | Scotch main line | The Scotch trades tension for immediate central clarity. |
|
 | | |
| 06 | Scotch ...Bc5 | ...Bc5 increases pressure on d4 and f2; answer with development. |
|
 | | |
| 07 | Latvian Gambit | Against ...f5, calculate checks and queen attacks before keeping material. |
|
 | | |
| 08 | Elephant Gambit | Return material if necessary; Black's compensation depends on development. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

Petroff main line



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Nxe5 d6 4. Nf3 Nxe4 5. d4 d5 6. Bd3 Nc6 7. O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

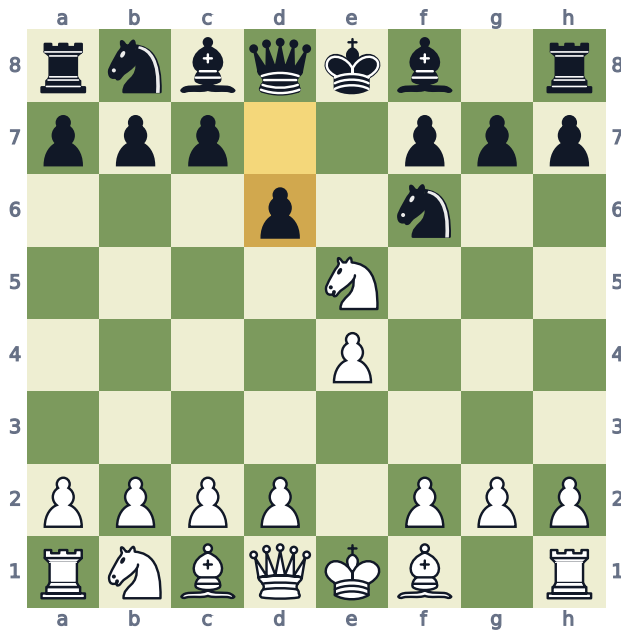
Use central space and active development in a symmetrical structure.

MAIN DANGER

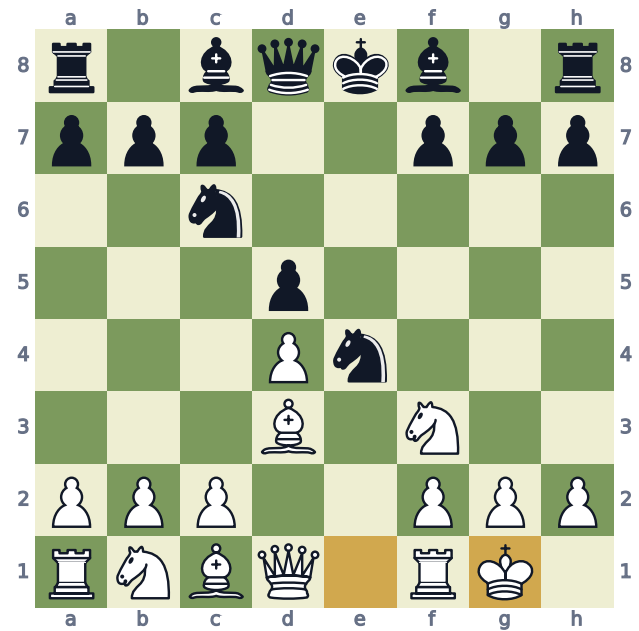
The e-file and e4 knight create tactical details.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

After the forced exchanges, d4 and Bd3 give White the easier development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

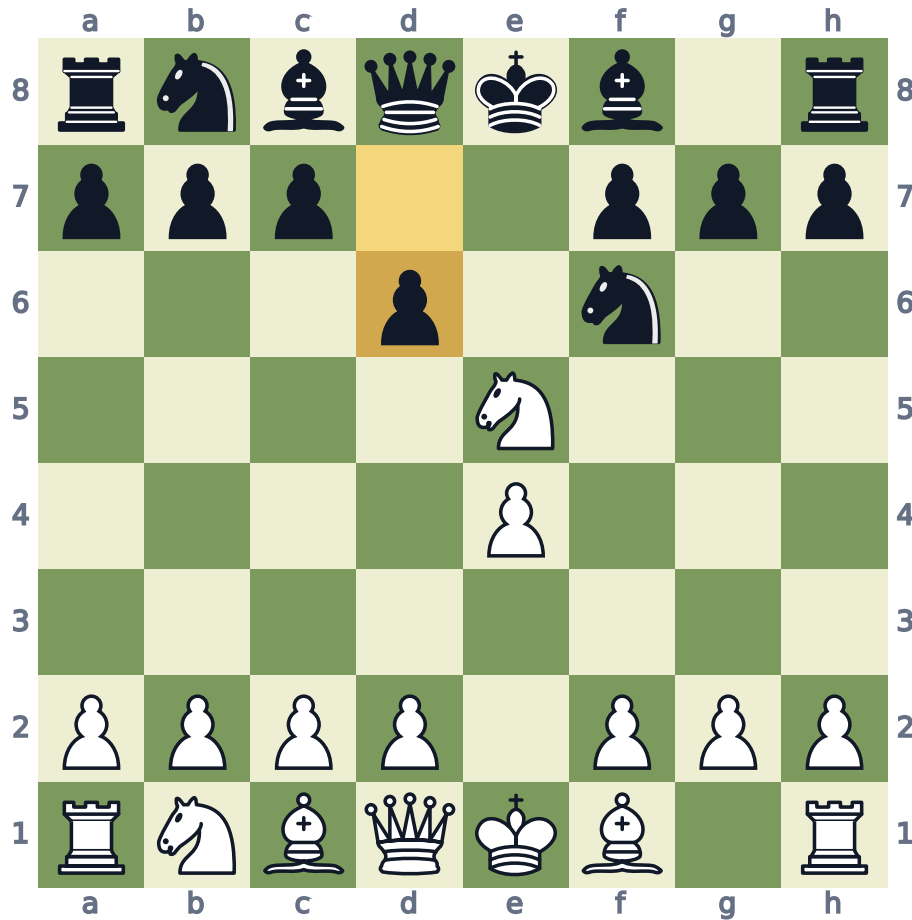
Position estimate: +0.52 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Be7 c4 2. Nb4 Re1 3. Nxd3 Qxd3 4. c6 cxd5 5. cxd5 Nc3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

Petroff main line



YOUR TASK

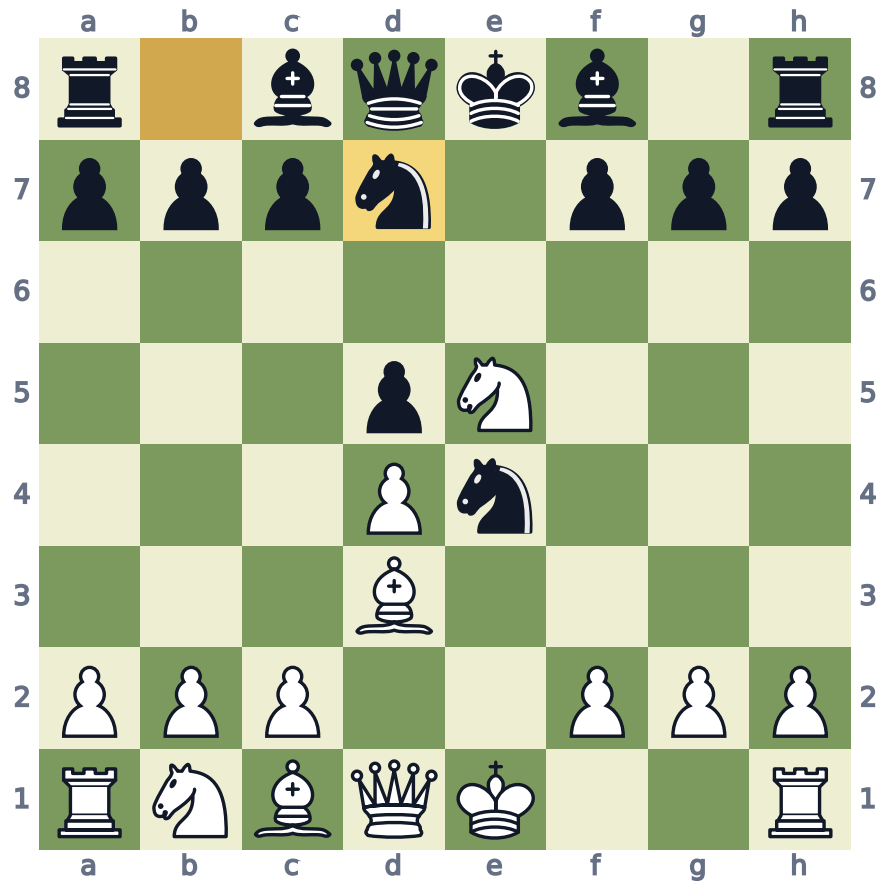
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

Petroff with 3.d4



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. d4 Nxe4 4. Bd3 d5 5. Nxe5 Nd7

WHITE'S IDEA

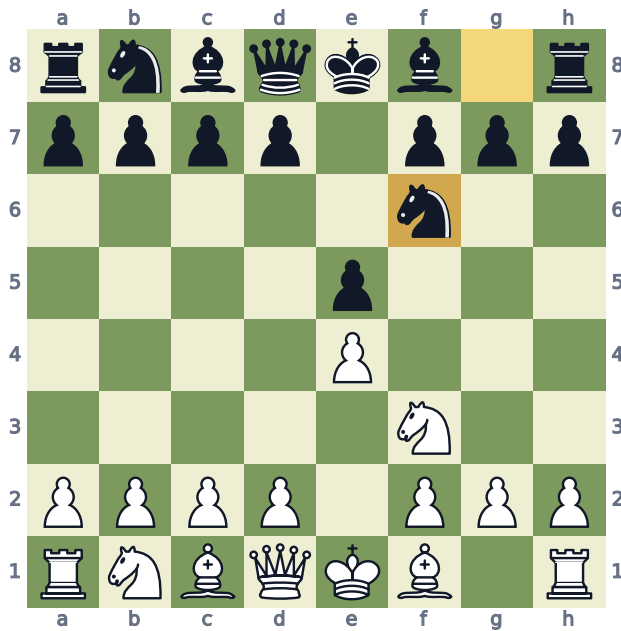
Use immediate central play to avoid pure symmetry.

MAIN DANGER

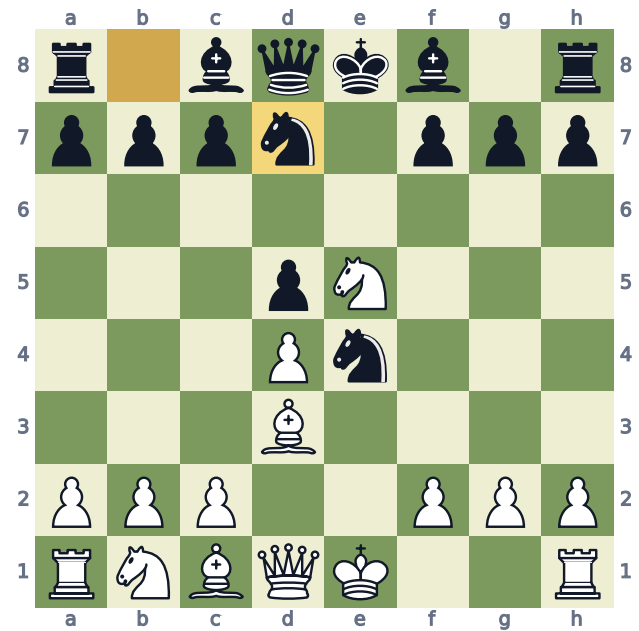
The e5 knight can be challenged by ...Nxe5 or ...Bd6.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

3.d4 changes the question from pawn recovery to central activity.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

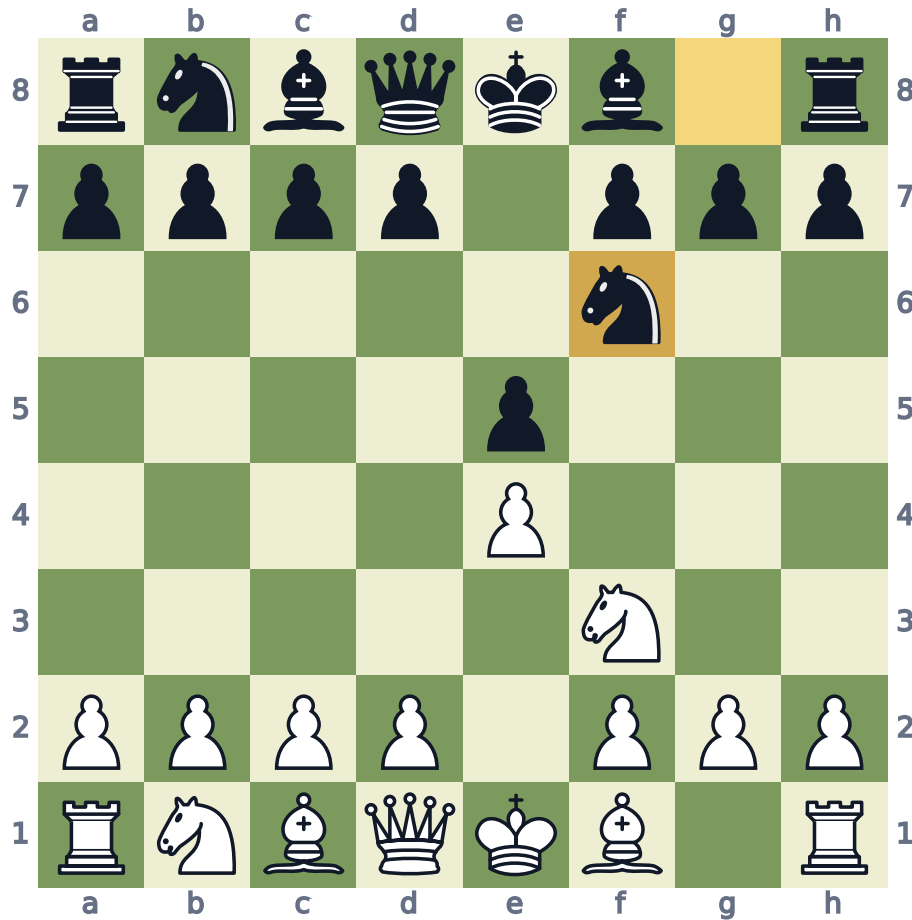
Position estimate: +0.37 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nxd7 Bxd7 2. O-O Be7 3. c4 c6 4. Bxe4 dxe4 5. Nc3 f5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

Petroff with 3.d4



YOUR TASK

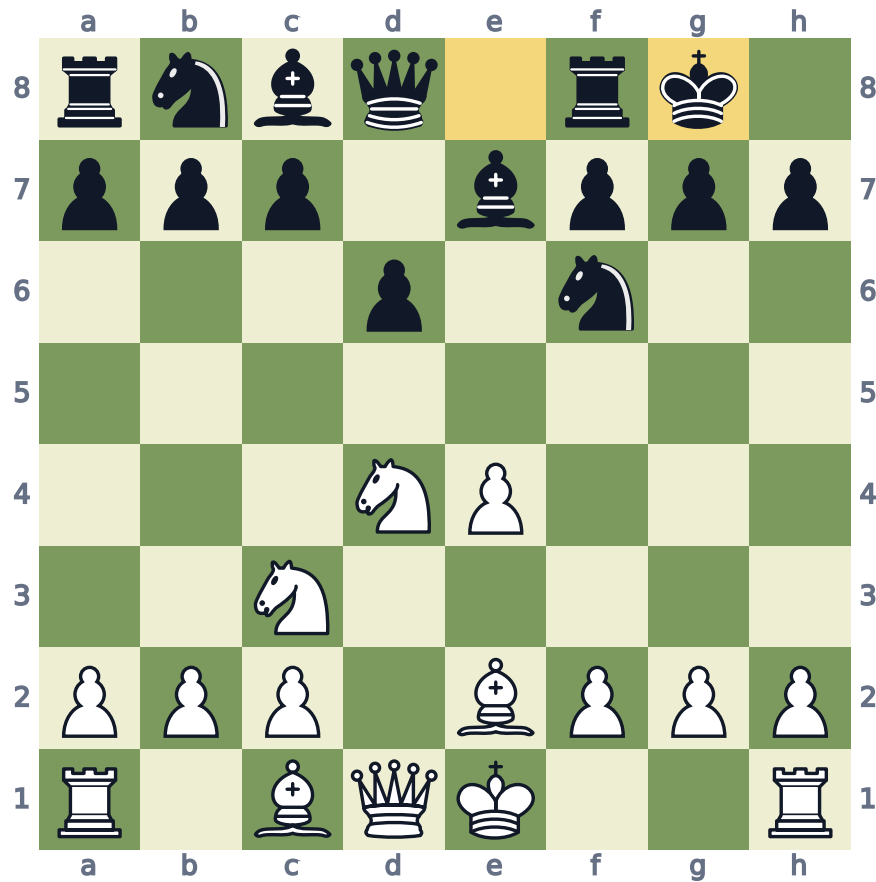
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

Philidor exchange



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 exd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Be2 O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

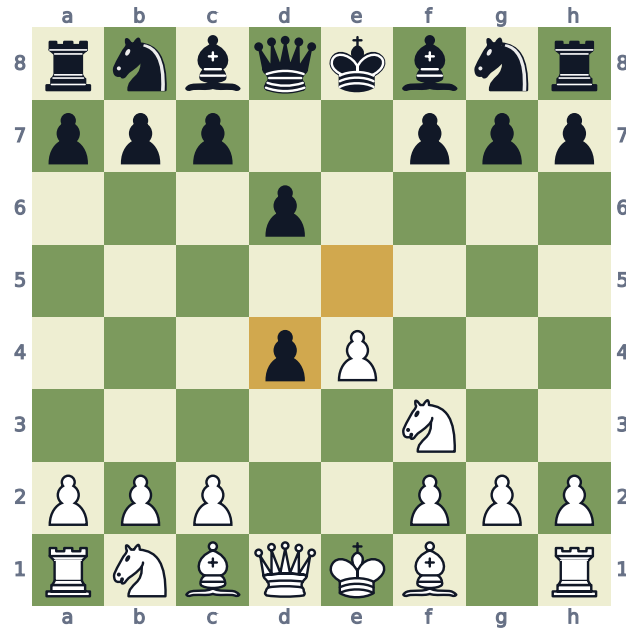
Use the open center and easier development.

MAIN DANGER

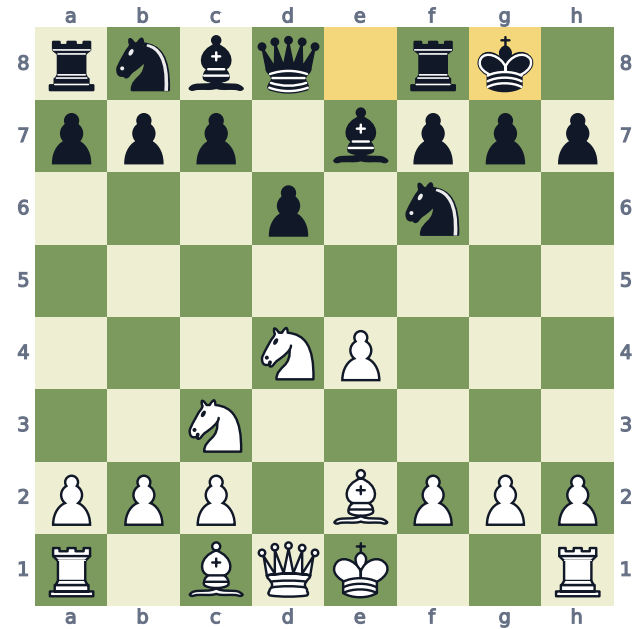
A careless f4 can expose e4 and the king.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Exchange on d4 when it opens lines against Black's cramped pieces.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

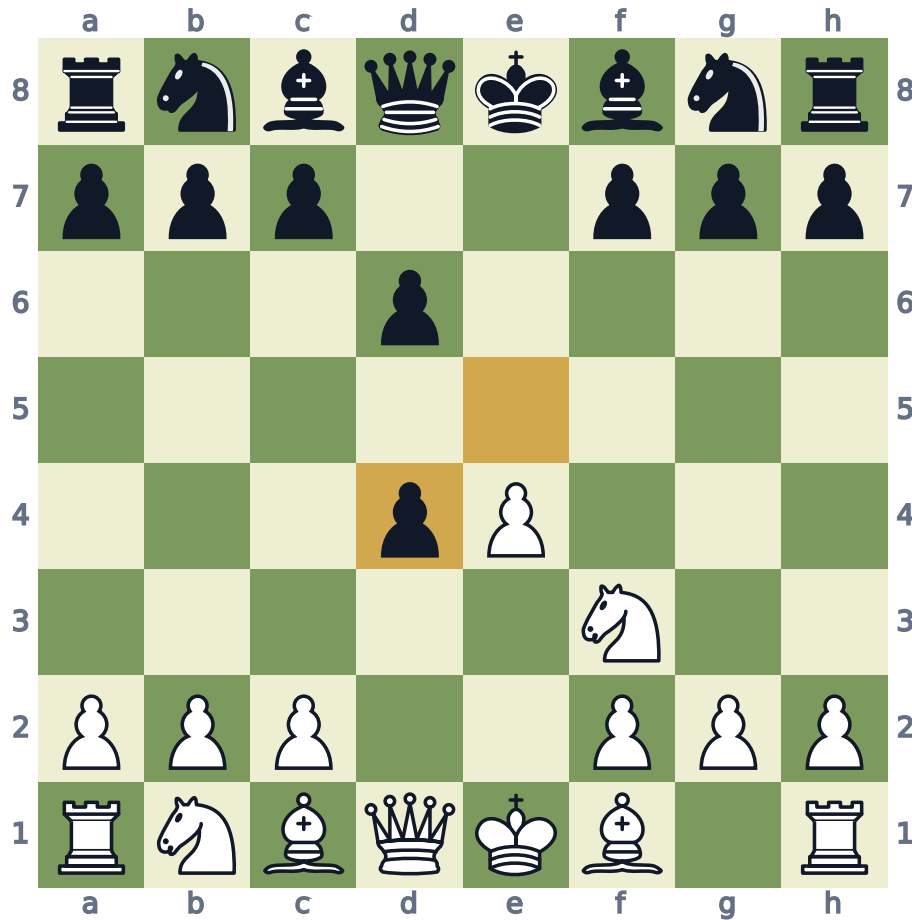
Position estimate: +0.57 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bf4 c6 2. Qd2 b5 3. Bf3 b4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

Philidor exchange



YOUR TASK

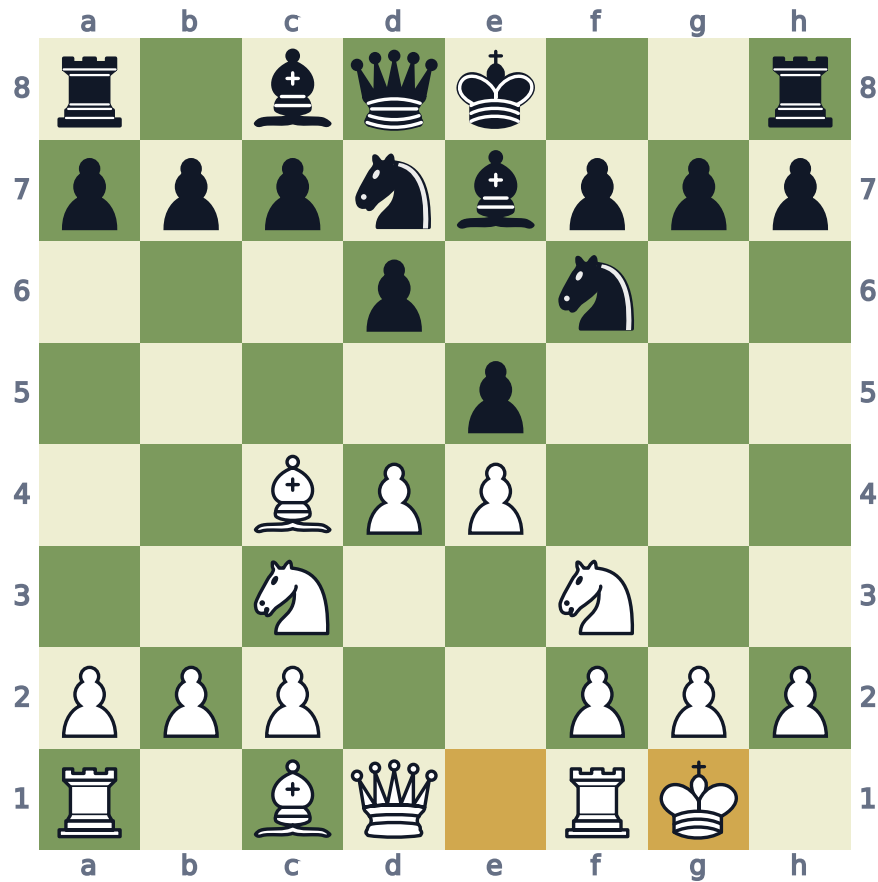
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Philidor ...Nf6



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7 6. O-O

WHITE'S IDEA

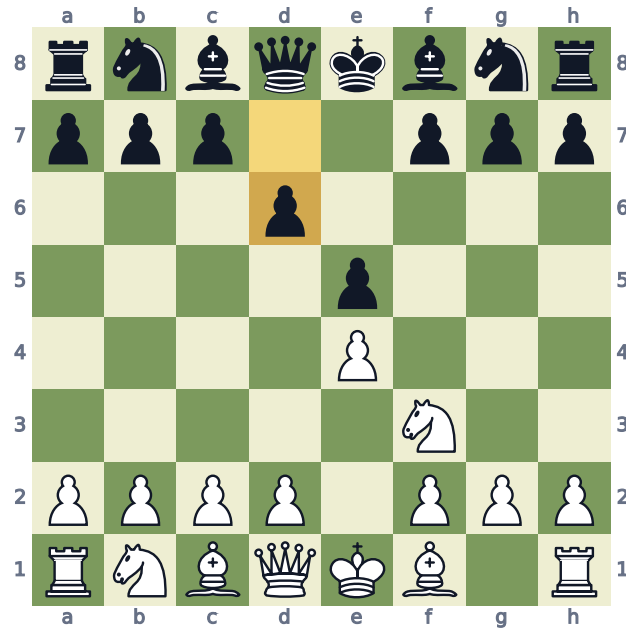
Develop naturally and keep d5 as a possible space gain.

MAIN DANGER

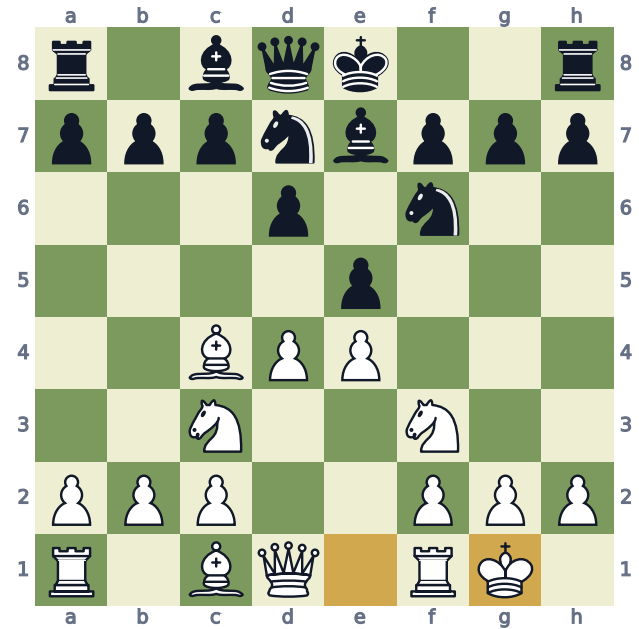
Black can strike with ...c6 and ...d5 if White drifts.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The Hanham setup is solid; improve pieces before forcing matters.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

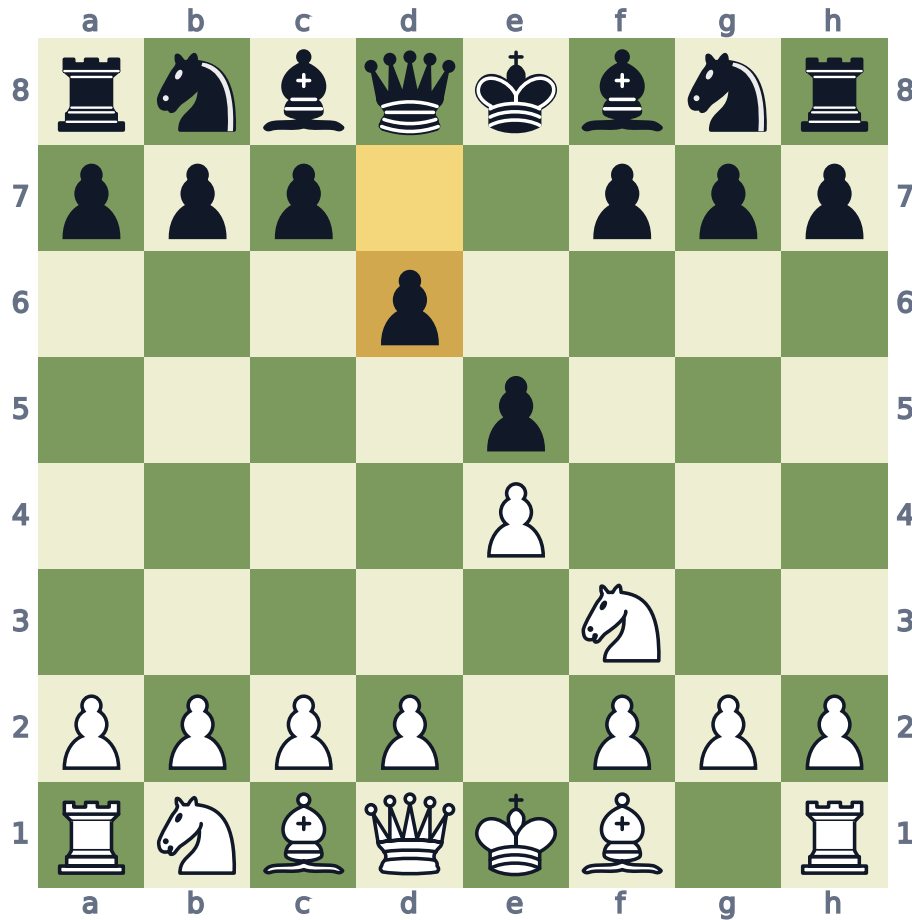
Position estimate: +0.57 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. c6 a4 2. O-O Re1 3. a5 h3 4. h6 Be3 5. Re8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Philidor ...Nf6



YOUR TASK

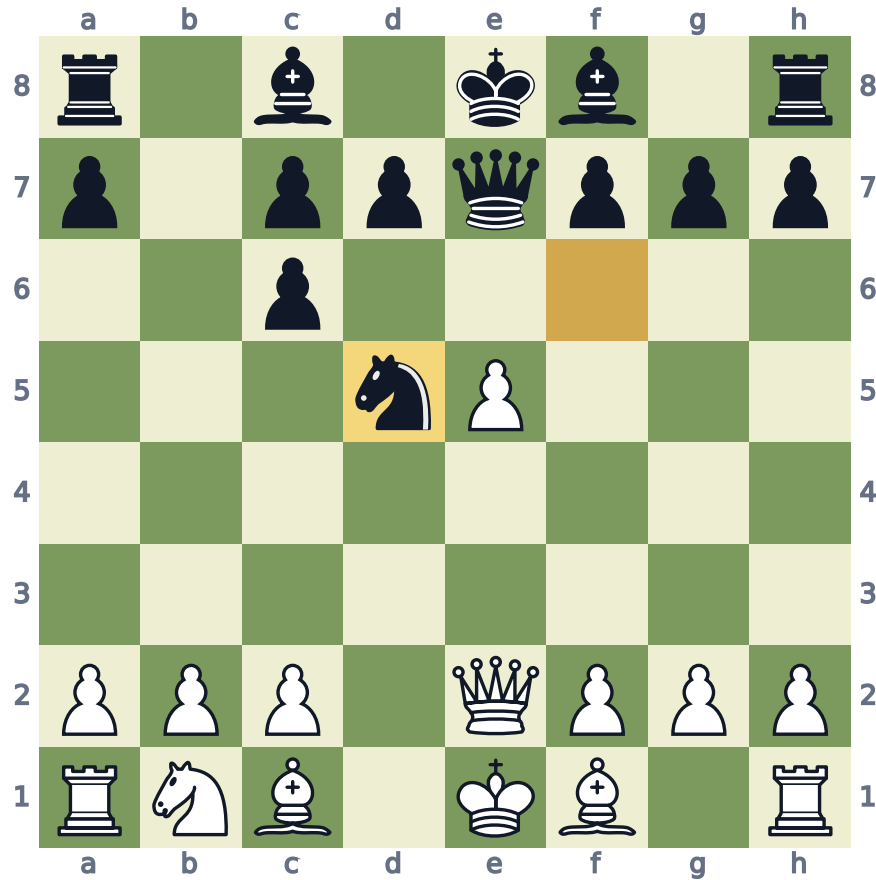
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Scotch main line



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 exd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2 Nd5

WHITE'S IDEA

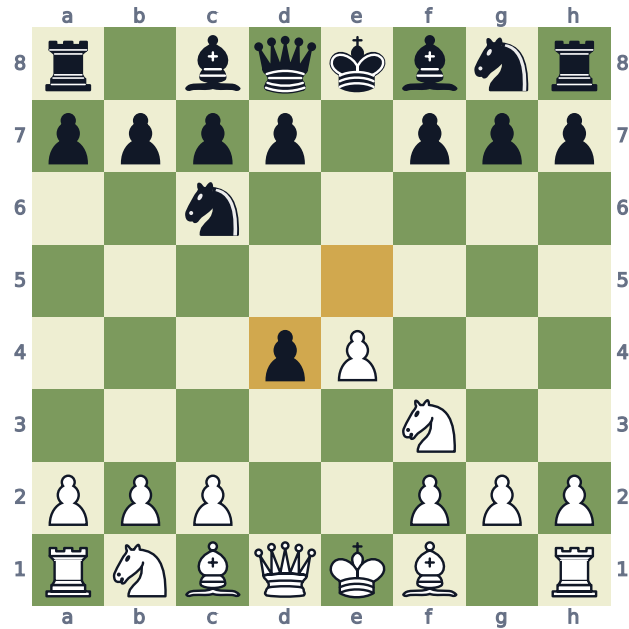
Open the center and use development against Black's structure.

MAIN DANGER

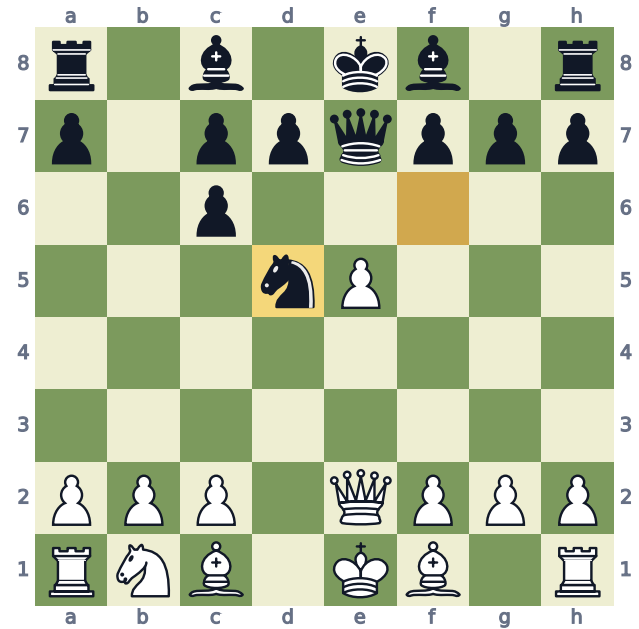
The advanced e5 pawn can be attacked with ...d6.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

The Scotch trades tension for immediate central clarity.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

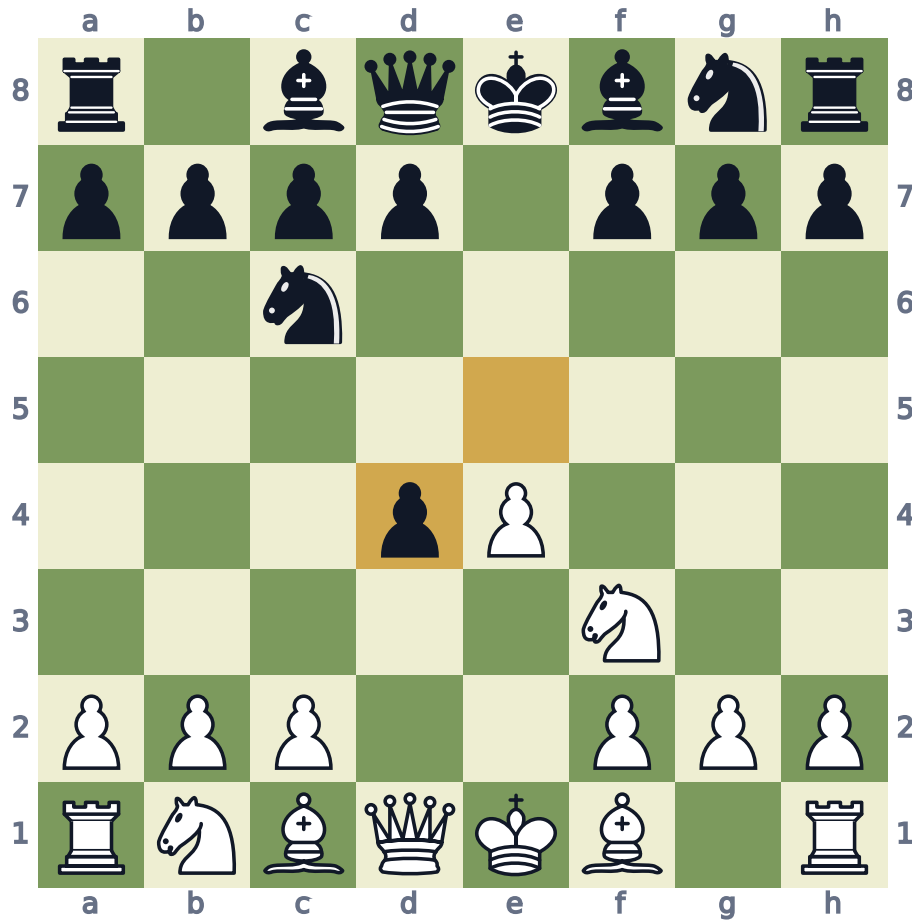
Position estimate: +0.21 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. g3 Qe6 2. c4 Nb6 3. Nd2 d5 4. exd6 cxd6 5. Bg2 Qxe2+

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Scotch main line



YOUR TASK

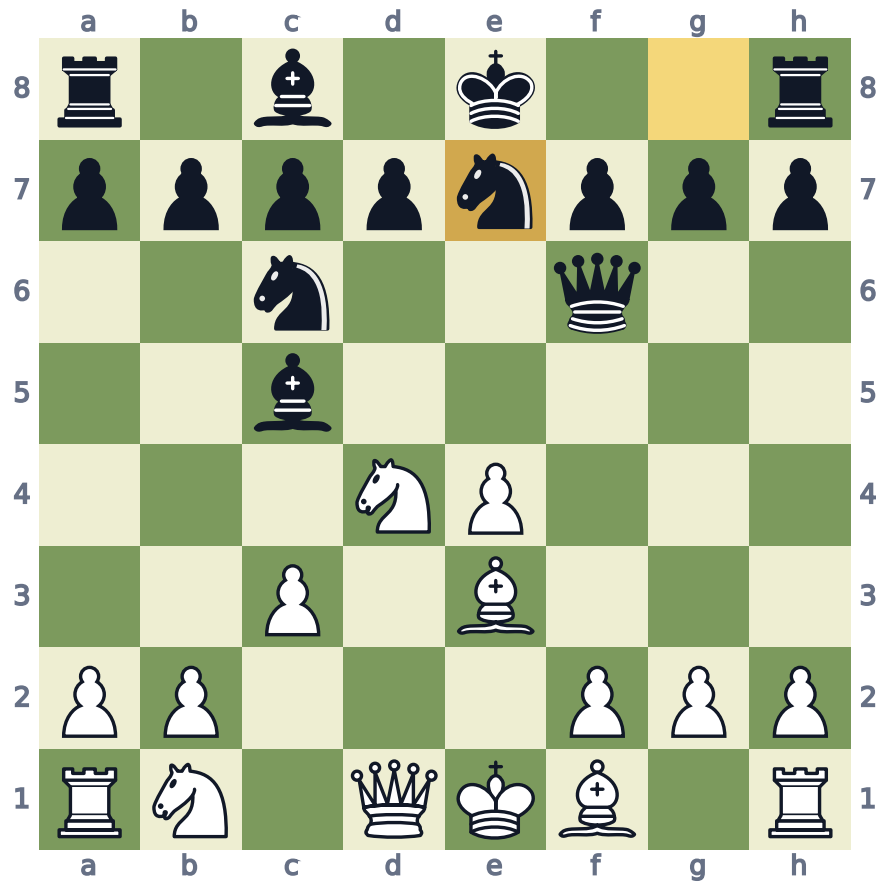
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Scotch ...Bc5



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 exd4 4. Nxd4 Bc5 5. Be3 Qf6 6. c3 Nge7

WHITE'S IDEA

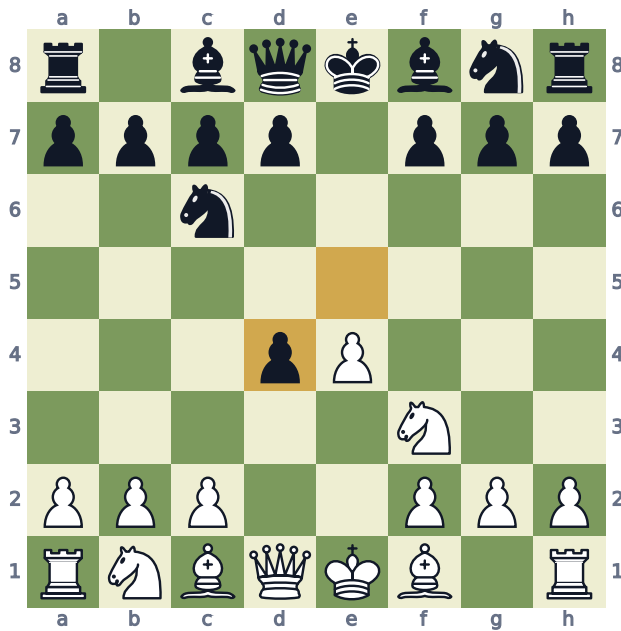
Develop with Be3 and support the center while meeting pressure on d4.

MAIN DANGER

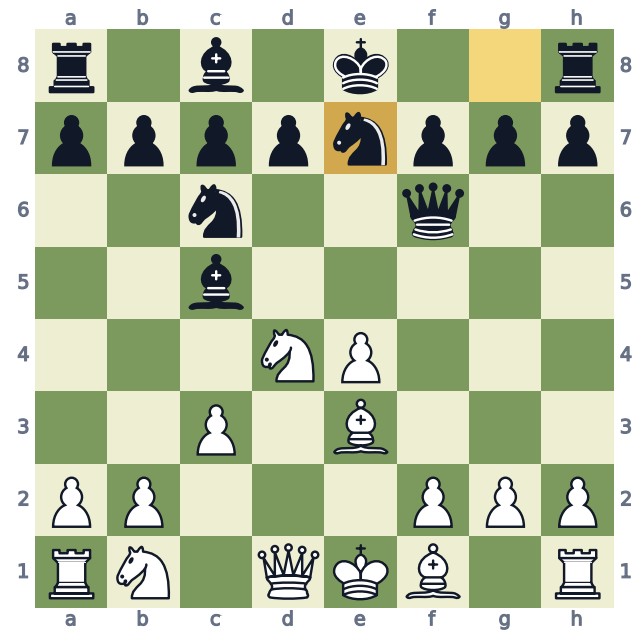
Nxc6 can help Black's queen develop with tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Bc5 increases pressure on d4 and f2; answer with development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

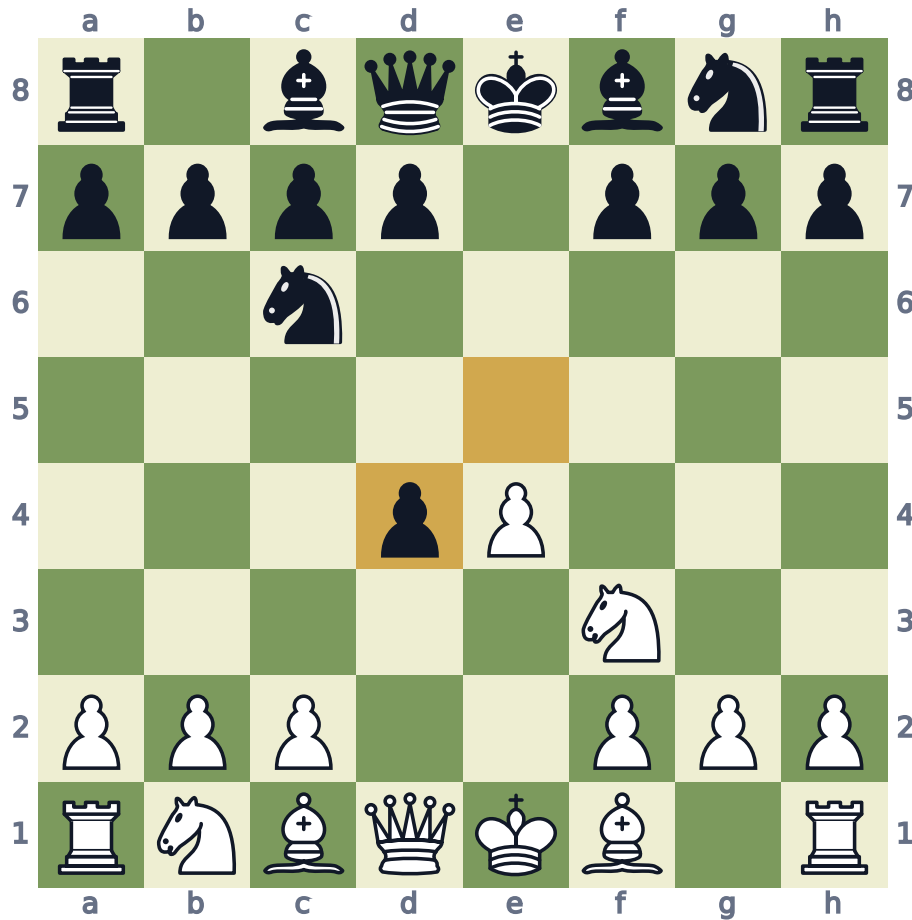
Position estimate: +0.18 for White (equal). Principal continuation: 1. Bc4 Ne5 2. Be2 d5 3. Nd2 O-O 4. O-O Bb6 5. a4 N5c6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Scotch ...Bc5



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Latvian Gambit



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 f5 3. Nxe5 Qf6 4. d4 d6 5. Nc4 fxe4 6. Nc3

WHITE'S IDEA

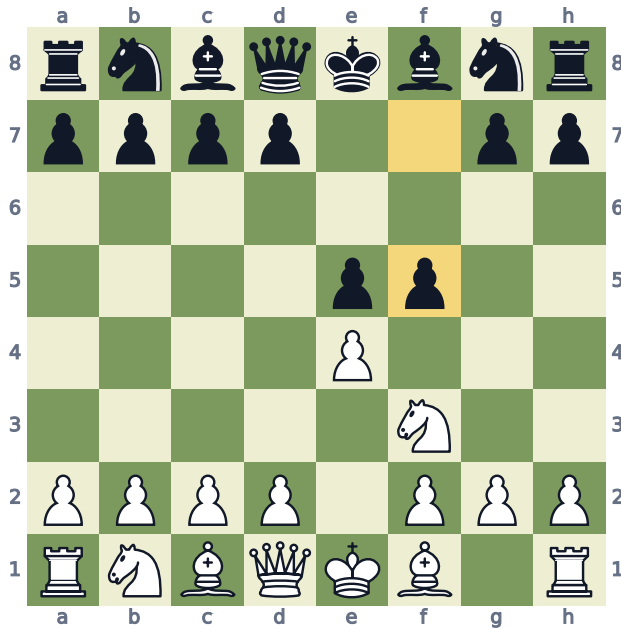
Take the center pawn, meet the queen attack, and develop with tempo.

MAIN DANGER

The queen and f-pawn create immediate threats against e4.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against ...f5, calculate checks and queen attacks before keeping material.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

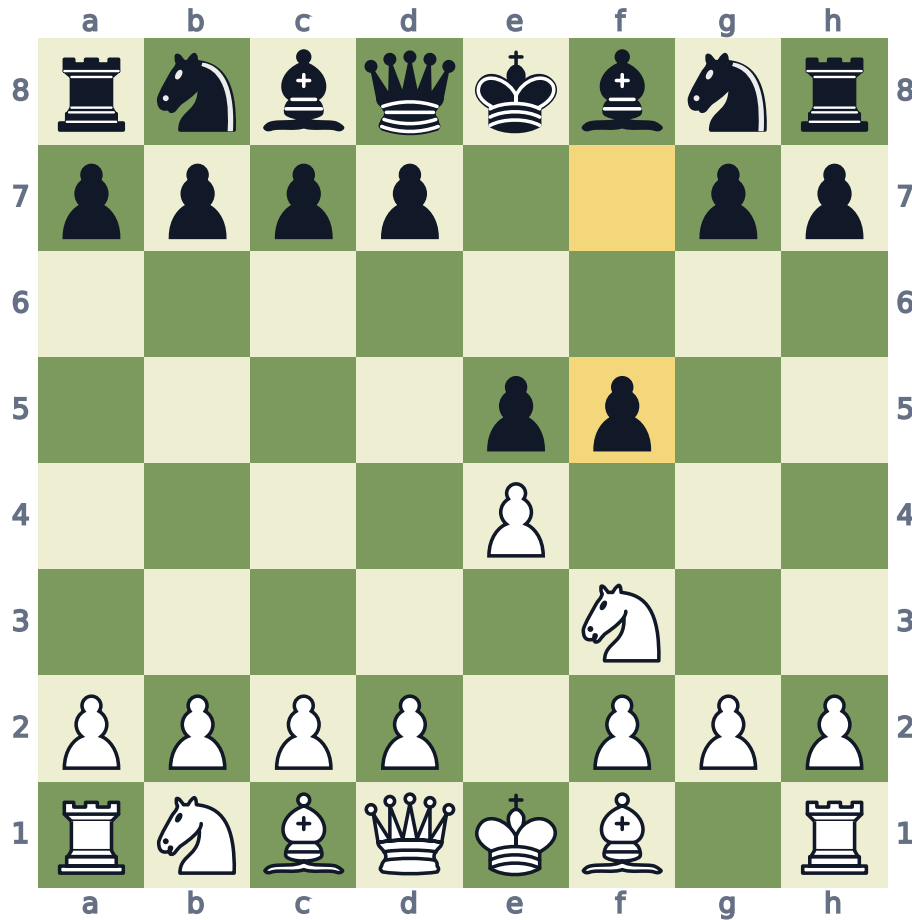
Position estimate: +1.48 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Qg6 h4 2. Nf6 h5 3. Qf7 Bg5 4. Be7 h6 5. Bg4 Qd2

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Latvian Gambit



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

Elephant Gambit



COURSE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 d5 3. exd5 Bd6 4. d4 e4 5. Qe2 Nf6

WHITE'S IDEA

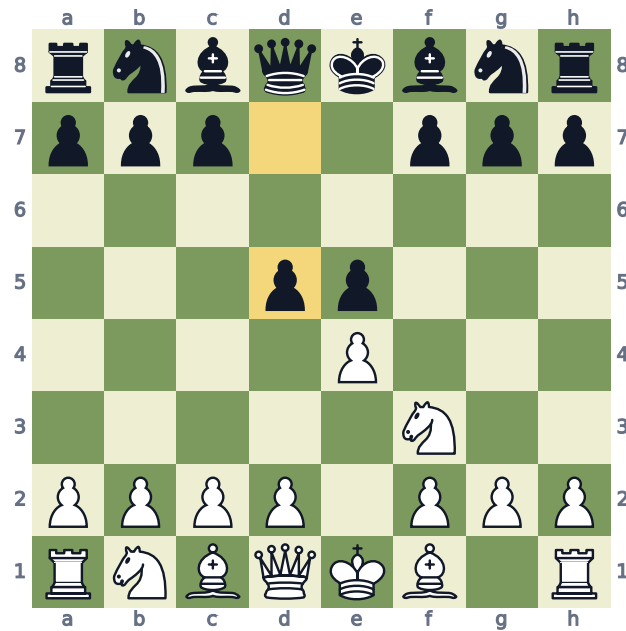
Accept the pawn but prioritize development and central control.

MAIN DANGER

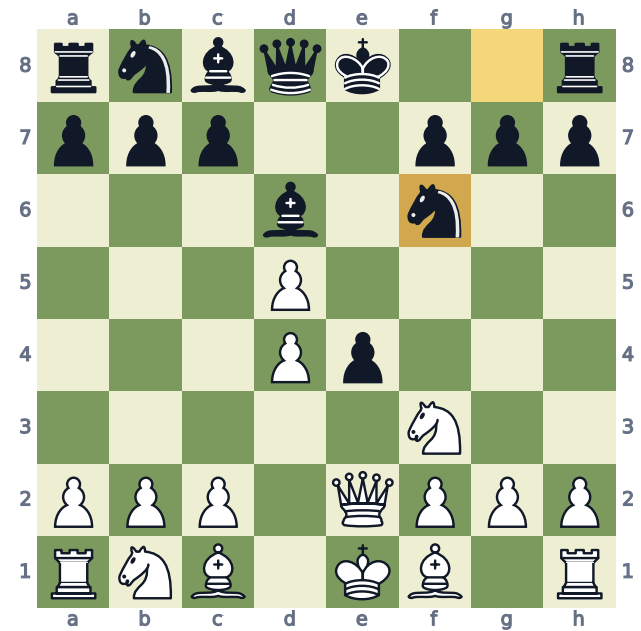
The e4 pawn can chase the knight and open lines with tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Return material if necessary; Black's compensation depends on development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

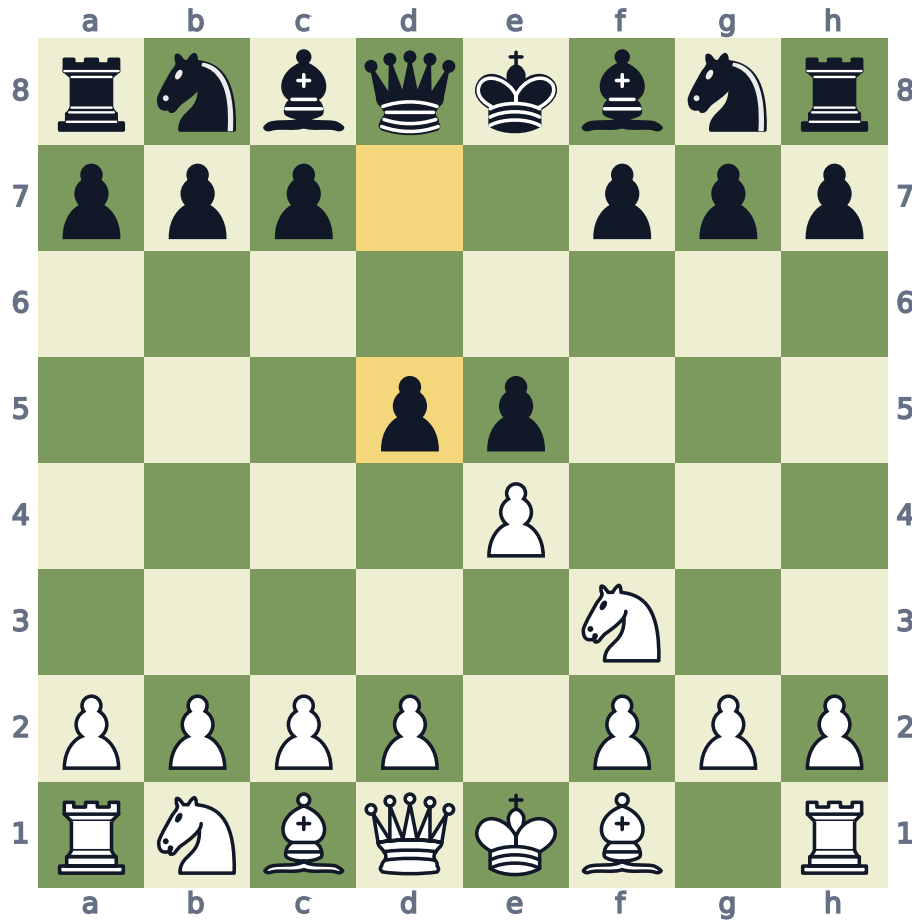
Position estimate: +1.19 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Bg5 O-O 2. Nfd2 Bg4 3. Bxf6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

Elephant Gambit



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. PETROFF MAIN LINE

Course move: Nf3. Purpose: Use central space and active development in a symmetrical structure. Engine comparison: 1. Nf3 Nxe4 2. d4 d5 3. Bd3 Bd6 4. O-O O-O 5. c4 c6 (+0.51 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The e-file and e4 knight create tactical details.

02. PETROFF WITH 3.D4

Course move: d4. Purpose: Use immediate central play to avoid pure symmetry. Engine comparison: 1. d4 exd4 2. e5 Ne4 3. Qxd4 d5 4. exd6 Nxd6 5. Bf4 Nc6 (+0.55 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The e5 knight can be challenged by ...Nxe5 or ...Bd6.

03. PHILIDOR EXCHANGE

Course move: Nxd4. Purpose: Use the open center and easier development. Engine comparison: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 Be7 3. Bf4 O-O 4. Qd2 Nc6 5. O-O-O Nxd4 (+0.70 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: A careless f4 can expose e4 and the king.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. PHILIDOR ...NF6

Course move: d4. Purpose: Develop naturally and keep d5 as a possible space gain. Engine comparison: 1. d4 exd4 2. Nxd4 Nf6 3. Nc3 Be7 4. Bf4 Nc6 (+0.76 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Black can strike with ...c6 and ...d5 if White drifts.

05. SCOTCH MAIN LINE

Course move: Nxd4. Purpose: Open the center and use development against Black's structure. Engine comparison: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nxc6 bxc6 3. Bd3 d5 4. Qe2 dxe4 5. Nc3 Bb4 (+0.22 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The advanced e5 pawn can be attacked with ...d6.

06. SCOTCH ...BC5

Course move: Nxd4. Purpose: Develop with Be3 and support the center while meeting pressure on d4. Engine comparison: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nxc6 bxc6 3. Bd3 d5 4. Qe2 dxe4 5. Nc3 Bb4 (+0.22 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Nxc6 can help Black's queen develop with tempo.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. LATVIAN GAMBIT

Course move: Nxe5. Purpose: Take the center pawn, meet the queen attack, and develop with tempo. Engine comparison: 1. Nxe5 Qf6 2. d4 d6 3. Nc4 fxe4 4. Nc3 Qg6 5. f3 Nc6 (+1.49 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The queen and f-pawn create immediate threats against e4.

08. ELEPHANT GAMBIT

Course move: exd5. Purpose: Accept the pawn but prioritize development and central control. Engine comparison: 1. exd5 e4 2. Qe2 Nf6 3. d3 Qxd5 4. Nbd2 Bb4 (+1.07 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The e4 pawn can chase the knight and open lines with tempo.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.